

AP WORLD HISTORY: MODERN · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

1200 CE to Present — Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 · every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 9 UNITS · 4 ERAS · 6 THEMES

About this exam. AP World History: Modern covers 1200 CE to present, tracing global developments across regions. The exam emphasizes COMPARISON across regions and CHANGE OVER TIME — these are the analytical skills that distinguish 4s from 5s.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (55 q, 40%)	SAQ (3 q, 20%)	DBQ + LEQ (40%)	Tier focus
3	~28 / 55 (~51%)	~5 / 9	5 / 13 raw	[3] only
4	~35 / 55 (~64%)	~6 / 9	8 / 13 raw	[3] + [4]
5	~42 / 55 (~76%)	~7-8 / 9	10-12 / 13 raw	All three

THE 9 UNITS — by exam weight + era grouping

#	Unit	Weight	Era
1	The Global Tapestry	8–10%	ERA 1: 1200–1450
2	Networks of Exchange	8–10%	ERA 1: 1200–1450
3	Land-Based Empires	12–15%	ERA 2: 1450–1750
4	Transoceanic Interconnections	12–15%	ERA 2: 1450–1750
5	Revolutions	12–15%	ERA 3: 1750–1900
6	Consequences of Industrialization	12–15%	ERA 3: 1750–1900
7	Global Conflict	8–10%	ERA 4: 1900–present
8	Cold War and Decolonization	8–10%	ERA 4: 1900–present
9	Globalization	8–10%	ERA 4: 1900–present

THE 6 THEMES — every prompt ties to one (or more) [3]/[4]

Code	Theme	What it captures
GOV	Governance	States, governments, political organization. Empire-building, colonization, revolutions.
ECN	Economic Systems	Trade networks, labor systems, industrialization, capitalism, communism.
CDI	Cultural Developments and Interactions	Religion, art, philosophy, science. Diffusion across regions.
SOC	Social Interactions and Organization	Class, gender, race, family structures.
TEC	Technology and Innovation	Tech advances + their social/economic consequences.
ENV	Humans and the Environment	How humans shape + are shaped by their environment. Disease, migration, resource use.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Every FRQ ties to one of these themes. Naming the theme explicitly in your response — "Following the GOV theme, this development reflects how empires..." — earns sophistication credit.

PAGE 2 | MCQ MASTERY + MASTER VOCABULARY

MCQ STRATEGY — 55 questions, 55 minutes [3]/[4]

- [3] **Most MCQs are source-based.** Each cluster has 3-4 questions about a primary source (text, image, map, chart). Read the attribution + date FIRST — that pins the era.
- [3] **Eliminate by era.** A document from 1850s shouldn't have answer about 1200s development. Wrong-era options can be cut immediately.
- [3] **Eliminate by region.** Trans-Saharan trade ≠ Indian Ocean trade. Get the region right, eliminate options outside it.
- [4] **Watch for too-extreme answers.** "Completely transformed" / "Always" / "Never" are usually wrong.
- [4] **Watch for anachronism.** "Used machine guns in 1750" — wrong, machine guns came late 19th century.

MASTER VOCABULARY — 30 high-frequency terms [3]/[4]

Term	Definition + era
Silk Roads [3]	Overland trade routes connecting East Asia to Mediterranean. Peak: Mongol era (~1200-1350).
Indian Ocean trade [3]	Maritime trade network across Indian Ocean. Monsoon-driven. Peak: 1200-1500.
Trans-Saharan trade [3]	Caravan routes across Sahara. Gold from Mali; salt from north. Peak: 1200-1500.
Mongol Empire [3]	Largest contiguous land empire ever (Genghis + Kublai Khan, 1206-~1368). Pax Mongolica enabled trade + cultural exchange.
Black Death [3]	Bubonic plague pandemic ~1347-1353. Spread along Silk Roads. Killed 1/3 of Europe; reshaped labor + religion.
Columbian Exchange [3]	Post-1492 transfer of plants, animals, diseases, people between Americas and Afro-Eurasia. Devastating for Native populations.
Encomienda + hacienda [4]	Spanish colonial labor + estate systems exploiting Native + African labor.
Mit'a / mita [4]	Inca-origin labor system continued under Spanish for mines (Potosí silver).
Triangular trade [3]	Atlantic system: Europe → Africa (manufactures) → Americas (slaves) → Europe (sugar/tobacco).
Mercantilism [3]	Economic system: state-controlled trade for accumulating bullion. 1500s-1700s.
Joint-stock company [4]	Investor-funded trading companies (Dutch VOC, English EIC). Combined state + private power.
Enlightenment [3]	European intellectual movement, ~1685-1815. Reason, individual rights, social contract. Inspired revolutions.
Industrial Revolution [3]	Began Britain ~1750-1850. Mechanization, factories, fossil fuels. Reshaped labor, family, environment.
Colonialism / Imperialism [3]	European political/economic domination of Asia, Africa, Latin America. Peak: 1880s-1914 "Scramble for Africa."
Nationalism [3]	Loyalty to nation/ethnic group above other identities. Drove unifications (Germany, Italy) AND revolutions.
Scramble for Africa [4]	1880s-1914 partition of Africa among European powers (Berlin Conference 1884).
Capitalism vs Communism [3]	Economic ideologies. Cold War-era fundamental conflict.
Total war [4]	Mobilization of entire society for war. WWI, WWII. Civilian targets become legitimate.
Decolonization [3]	Post-WWII independence movements. Mostly 1945-1975.
Cold War [3]	US-USSR rivalry, 1947-1991. Proxy wars, arms race, ideological competition.
Non-Aligned Movement [4]	Newly-independent states refusing to ally with US or USSR. Founded Bandung 1955.
Globalization [3]	Economic + cultural integration of world economies. Accelerated post-1990.
WTO / IMF / World Bank [4]	Post-WWII economic institutions promoting global trade + development.
Bretton Woods [4]	1944 conference setting up post-WWII economic order. Established IMF + World Bank.
Green Revolution [4]	Mid-20th century agricultural innovations (high-yield seeds, fertilizers). Massively boosted food production but ecological costs.
Diaspora [3]	Dispersion of a people from homeland. Examples: African (slave trade), Jewish, South Asian (post-1947).
Subaltern [5]	Term for marginalized colonized peoples. Subaltern studies emphasized non-elite voices.
Maroon communities [4]	Self-liberated enslaved Africans forming free communities (Suriname, Brazil, Jamaica).
Coueurs de bois / voyageurs [4]	French fur traders in Americas; example of cultural blending.
Devshirme [4]	Ottoman child levy — Christian boys taken, converted, trained for military/administration. Source of Janissaries.

ERA 1 | 1200–1450 · Global Tapestry + Networks of Exchange

Big picture. This era is about the **state of the world before European maritime expansion** — major civilizations and trade networks operating mostly independently. Key developments: rise of the Mongol Empire, expansion of Indian Ocean trade, spread of Islam, Black Death.

Major Civilizations + States [3]/[4]

Civilization / State	Key features
Song China [3]	Innovation: gunpowder, printing, compass. Confucian bureaucracy via exam system. Foot binding. Commercial revolution.
Yuan / Ming China [3]	Yuan = Mongol-ruled China (Kublai Khan). Ming followed (1368), restored Han rule. Voyages of Zheng He (1405-1433).
Delhi Sultanate [3]	Muslim rulers of N India ~1206-1526. Cultural blending Islam + Hindu.
Mali Empire [3]	West African empire. Mansa Musa's hajj (1324) showcased gold wealth. Timbuktu = scholarly center.
Byzantine Empire [4]	Eastern Roman Empire continuation. Fell to Ottomans in 1453.
Holy Roman Empire / Catholic Europe [4]	Decentralized political authority but unified by Latin Christianity. Gothic architecture, scholasticism.
Aztec Empire [3]	Mesoamerica ~1428-1521. Tenochtitlán. Tribute-based empire. Human sacrifice.
Inca Empire [3]	Andes ~1438-1533. Mit'a labor system. Quipu record-keeping. Roads + terraced agriculture.
Mongol Empire [3]	1206~1368. Largest contiguous land empire. Pax Mongolica facilitated trade + cultural exchange.

Major Trade Networks [3]/[4]

Network	What flowed	Key intermediaries
Silk Roads [3]	Silk, porcelain, paper (E→W); horses, gold (W→E). Also Buddhism + plague.	Mongol Empire enabled at peak
Indian Ocean trade [3]	Spices, textiles, slaves, ideas (Islam). Monsoon-driven seasonal sailing.	Swahili coast, Gujarat merchants, Malacca
Trans-Saharan trade [3]	Gold (S→N), salt (N→S), enslaved people, ivory. Camel caravans.	Mali Empire, Berber merchants
Mediterranean trade [4]	Connected Europe-Africa-Middle East. Spices, slaves, textiles.	Italian city-states (Venice, Genoa)

Religion + Cultural Diffusion [3]/[4]

- [3] **Islam** spread along Indian Ocean + Saharan trade + military conquest. By 1450: dominant in N. Africa, Middle East, parts of South Asia, expanding into SE Asia.
- [3] **Buddhism** spread along Silk Roads, deep into China + East Asia. Different schools (Theravada, Mahayana, Zen).
- [4] **Neo-Confucianism** revived in Song China, blending Confucian ethics with Buddhist/Daoist metaphysics.
- [4] **Christian schism**: Catholic (Western) vs Orthodox (Eastern) split formally 1054.

Black Death [3]/[4]

1347-1353. Bubonic plague spread along Silk Roads + Mediterranean. Killed ~1/3 of Europe. Effects: labor shortages → end of European feudalism; religious questioning; persecution of Jews; transformation of art (death imagery).

ERA 2 | 1450–1750 · Land Empires + Transoceanic Connections

Big picture. Two parallel transformations: **gunpowder land empires** consolidate (Ottoman, Mughal, Russian, Ming/Qing); **European maritime expansion** opens transoceanic networks (Columbian Exchange, Atlantic slave trade).

The Gunpowder Empires [3]/[4]

Empire	Key features
Ottoman [3]	Sunni Muslim. Capital Constantinople (1453 conquest). Devshirme + Janissaries. Religious tolerance via millet system. Peak: Suleiman the Magnificent (mid-1500s).
Safavid [3]	Shi'a Muslim. Iran/Persia ~1501-1736. Promoted Shi'ism. Conflict with Sunni Ottomans.
Mughal [3]	Muslim rulers of Hindu-majority India. Akbar (1556-1605) promoted religious tolerance. Aurangzeb (later) reversed it. Architectural marvels (Taj Mahal).
Russia [4]	Ivan IV (Terrible). Romanov dynasty (1613). Peter the Great (Westernization). Expansion into Siberia.
Ming / Qing China [3]	Ming (1368-1644) ethnic Han; Qing (1644-1912) ethnic Manchu. Strict isolationism (mostly). Tribute system.
Tokugawa Japan [4]	1603-1868. Shogunate centralized Japan. Sakoku (closed country) policy after 1639.

Maritime Expansion + Columbian Exchange [3]/[4]

- [3] **Portugal** led early voyages (Henry the Navigator, da Gama to India 1498).
- [3] **Spain** funded Columbus (1492); conquistadors (Cortés vs Aztec, Pizarro vs Inca).
- [3] **Dutch, English, French** followed; built joint-stock companies (VOC, EIC) for Asian trade.
- [3] **Columbian Exchange:** Old World → New (horses, cattle, wheat, smallpox, measles); New → Old (corn, potatoes, tomatoes, tobacco, sugar).
Devastating epidemic in Americas: ~80-90% of indigenous population died from disease.

Atlantic Slave Trade [3]/[4]

Estimated 12+ million Africans forcibly transported across Atlantic, 1500-1880s. 1.5+ million died in Middle Passage.

- [3] **Triangular trade** structure connected Europe + Africa + Americas.
- [4] **Plantation economy** in Brazil, Caribbean, southern N. America: sugar, tobacco, cotton.
- [4] **African states involvement** — coastal kingdoms (Dahomey, Kongo) profited initially, but the trade ultimately destabilized many African societies.
- [4] **Resistance + maroon communities** formed throughout Americas (Palmares in Brazil, Maroons in Jamaica).

Labor Systems Across Regions [4]

System	Region + features
Encomienda → Hacienda	Spanish Americas. Forced Native labor (encomienda 1500s); large estates (hacienda) later.
Mit'a (Spanish version)	Andes. Adapted from Inca. Forced rotation labor in mines (Potosí silver).
Chattel slavery	Atlantic system. People as property, racialized.
Indentured servitude	Voluntary contract labor; common in early N. America. Replaced with slavery as economy grew.
Serfdom (intensified)	Russia + Eastern Europe — opposite trend; serfdom strengthened as it declined in Western Europe.

ERA 3 | 1750–1900 · Revolutions + Industrialization

Big picture. Two intertwined revolutions transform the world: **Atlantic political revolutions** (American, French, Haitian, Latin American independence) inspired by Enlightenment; **Industrial Revolution** transforms economy + society + reshapes global power balance.

Atlantic Revolutions [3]/[4]

Revolution	Key features
American (1775-1783)	First successful colonial revolt. Inspired by Enlightenment. Constitution + Bill of Rights.
French (1789-1799)	End of absolute monarchy. Reign of Terror. Napoleon's empire (1799-1815) spread reforms across Europe.
Haitian (1791-1804) [3]	Only successful slave revolt that created an independent nation. Toussaint L'Ouverture. Inspired/scared other movements.
Latin American (1808-1830)	Sparked by Napoleonic disruption of Spain. Bolívar, San Martín led independence.

Industrial Revolution [3]/[4]

- [3] **Began Britain ~1750-1850.** Why Britain? Coal + iron deposits, navy, capital, agricultural revolution freed labor, colonies as markets.
- [3] **Stages:** First (steam, textiles, ~1760-1840); Second (steel, electricity, chemicals, ~1870-1914).
- [3] **Social effects:** urbanization, factory labor, child labor, working-class poverty, rising middle class, women's roles shift.
- [4] **Spread:** Britain → Belgium, France, Germany (1830s+) → US, Japan (late 1800s).
- [4] **Tech wave:** railroads, steamships, telegraph, photography. **Compressed space + time globally.**

Imperialism + Colonization [3]/[4]

"New imperialism" 1870s-1914. European powers + Japan + US carve up Africa, Asia, Pacific. Driven by industrial demand for raw materials, markets, prestige, social Darwinism.

- [3] **Scramble for Africa** — Berlin Conference (1884-85) divided Africa among European powers. By 1914, only Ethiopia + Liberia remained independent.
- [3] **India** — British East India Company → direct British rule after 1857 Sepoy Rebellion.
- [3] **China** — "unequal treaties" after Opium Wars (1839-42, 1856-60). Spheres of influence. Boxer Rebellion (1900).
- [4] **Japan** — Meiji Restoration (1868) industrialized + imperial. Defeated China (1895), Russia (1905). Joined imperial powers.
- [4] **Resistance** — Sepoy Mutiny, Boxer Rebellion, Mahdist Revolt, Zulu Wars. Most failed but seeded later nationalism.

Ideologies of the era [4]

- **Liberalism** — individual rights, constitutional government, free trade.
- **Nationalism** — loyalty to nation/ethnic group. Inspired Italian + German unifications; Latin American independence.
- **Marxism** (1848 Communist Manifesto) — class conflict, eventual socialism. Industrial workers as agents of change.
- **Social Darwinism** — Herbert Spencer applied evolution to society. Justified imperialism + racial hierarchy.

Migration + Diasporas [4]

Massive 19th-century migrations. Europeans to Americas (~50 million). Indians + Chinese as indentured laborers replacing slaves. Internal migrations (rural→urban). Created new diasporas + ethnic complexity.

ERA 4 | 1900–PRESENT · Global Conflict + Cold War + Globalization**Global Conflict — World Wars [3]/[4]**

- **[3] WWI (1914-1918)** — Causes: militarism, alliances, imperialism, nationalism, assassination of Archduke. Total war. ~16 million deaths. Russian Revolution (1917).
- **[3] Treaty of Versailles (1919)** — Punished Germany (war guilt, reparations); created League of Nations; redrew borders; mandated colonies. Sowed seeds of WWII.
- **[3] Interwar period** — Russian Revolution → USSR; rise of fascism (Mussolini 1922, Hitler 1933); Great Depression (1929).
- **[3] WWII (1939-1945)** — Started by German invasion of Poland. Total war. ~70 million deaths including Holocaust (~6 million Jews killed). US dropped atomic bombs on Japan (Aug 1945).

Cold War (1947-1991) [3]/[4]

- **[3] US (capitalist) vs USSR (communist)**. Bipolar world. Containment + arms race + space race.
- **[4] Hot proxies**: Korean War (1950-53), Vietnam War (1955-1975), Soviet-Afghan War (1979-1989).
- **[4] Crises**: Berlin Blockade (1948), Cuban Missile Crisis (1962), Berlin Wall (1961-1989).
- **[4] Decolonization** unfolded simultaneously (1945-1975). India (1947), Indonesia (1949), Ghana (1957), Algeria (1962), Vietnam (1975).
- **[4] Non-Aligned Movement** — Bandung Conference 1955. Newly independent states refusing alignment with either superpower.
- **[3] End** — Gorbachev's reforms (glasnost, perestroika). Berlin Wall falls 1989. USSR dissolves Dec 1991.

Decolonization Patterns [4]

Region / case	Pattern
India (1947)	Negotiated independence (Gandhi's nonviolent resistance + WWII weakening Britain). Partition into India + Pakistan; ~14M displaced, ~1M deaths.
Africa (1957-1980s)	Mostly negotiated; some violent (Algeria, Kenya Mau Mau, Angola, Mozambique). Borders inherited from colonial era → ethnic conflicts.
Vietnam (1954, 1975)	Violent — French defeated 1954; US then supported South Vietnam; communist North won 1975.
Apartheid South Africa (1994)	Independence retained white minority rule until 1994. Mandela elected first Black president.

Globalization + Modern Era [3]/[4]

- **[3] Post-1991** — accelerated economic integration. Internet, container shipping, free trade agreements (NAFTA 1994, EU expansion, WTO 1995).
- **[3] China's rise** — economic reforms under Deng Xiaoping (1978+). Now 2nd-largest economy.
- **[4] Climate change** — recognized as global crisis. Kyoto Protocol (1997), Paris Agreement (2015).
- **[4] Demographic shifts** — aging populations in Global North; population growth in Global South.
- **[4] Migration patterns** — Global South → Global North; refugees (Syria, Afghanistan, Central America).
- **[4] Religious + ethnic conflicts** — Yugoslavia (1990s), Rwanda Genocide (1994), various civil wars.
- **[4] Terrorism** — 9/11 (2001) → War on Terror, prolonged conflicts in Middle East.
- **[4] Pandemic** — COVID-19 (2020+) revealed global vulnerabilities + accelerated digital transformation.

PAGE 7 | COMPARATIVE FRAMEWORKS · the unique AP World skill

[5] AP World rewards **COMPARISON** across regions and **CHANGE OVER TIME** analysis. These are the analytical moves that distinguish 4-scorers from 5-scorers. Master these frameworks and you can answer almost any prompt with sophistication.

THE 3 REASONING SKILLS [3]/[4]

Skill	What it asks
Causation	Identify causes + effects of historical developments. "What caused industrialization?" "What were the effects of imperialism?"
Comparison	Identify similarities AND differences between societies, regions, or time periods. "Compare reactions to Western imperialism in China and Japan."
Continuity & Change Over Time (CCOT)	Identify what stayed the same vs what changed across a period. "How did labor systems change in the Americas, 1450-1750?"

COMPARATIVE FRAMEWORKS — when prompts ask you to compare [4]/[5]

Framework 1: Comparing across regions in same era. Example: How did East Asian + South Asian responses to Western imperialism differ?

Framework 2: Comparing same region across different eras. Example: How did labor systems in the Americas change from 1500 to 1900?

Framework 3: Comparing similar developments in different regions. Example: Compare the French and Haitian revolutions.

CCOT FRAMEWORKS — when prompts ask about change over time [4]/[5]

Always state: what **CONTINUED** + what **CHANGED** + **why**. Don't just describe — explain causes.

Common CCOT prompts:

- **Trade networks:** silk roads → Indian Ocean → transoceanic → globalization
- **Labor systems:** corvée/serfdom → encomienda → chattel slavery → indentured → wage labor
- **Religion + state:** theocracy → state religion → secular state → religious revival
- **Empires:** consolidation (1450-1750) → fragmentation/colonization → decolonization
- **Gender roles:** patriarchy throughout, but specific roles shifted with industrialization, suffrage movements, wars, post-1960s feminism

CROSS-REGIONAL CONNECTIONS — high-leverage comparative facts [5]

Phenomenon	Cross-regional comparison
Responses to Industrialization	Britain birthed it; Germany/Japan state-led catch-up; China failed initially, succeeded post-1978; Russia state-imposed under Stalin
Resistance to imperialism	India = nationalist movement (Gandhi, civil disobedience); China = internal rebellions (Boxer); Africa = armed resistance (Zulu, Mahdi); Japan = strategic adoption
Routes to modernization	Japan = top-down Meiji reforms; China = revolutionary (Maoist) then market (Deng); Turkey = secular nationalism (Atatürk); Iran = Islamic Revolution alternative path
Slavery + abolition	Haiti = revolution-led (1804); Britain = parliamentary (1833); US = civil war (1865); Brazil = gradual (1888); abolition didn't end racial hierarchy
Decolonization paths	India = negotiated; Algeria = bloody war; South Africa = retained internal colonialism (apartheid) until 1994

KEY INSIGHT [5] On comparative LEQs/DBQs, structure body paragraphs by similarity vs difference, not by region. Wrong: "Paragraph 1 about China, Paragraph 2 about Japan." Right: "Paragraph 1 about a similarity, Paragraph 2 about a difference, Paragraph 3 about deeper analysis." The structure itself shows comparative thinking.

PAGE 8 | FRQ STRATEGY · SAQ + DBQ + LEQ rubric mechanics**SAQ — 3 questions, 4 pts each, 40 min total [3]/[4]**

Format: Each SAQ has 3 parts (A/B/C). 3-4 minutes per part. **Bullets OK; complete sentences preferred.**

- **[3] Part A** — usually "Identify" or "Briefly describe." 1 specific fact. **Specificity + year matters.**
- **[3] Part B** — "Explain" — give a specific example AND say why it's relevant.
- **[3] Part C** — "Provide a difference" or "Provide an additional example." Different from A and B.

[4] Each answer must include a SPECIFIC historical example with year/place/event. Vague generalities = 0 points.

DBQ — 7 points, 1 hour [3]/[4]/[5]

Pts	Element	Tier	How to bag it
1	Thesis	[3]	Defensible claim with line of reasoning. "Although X, Y because R1 and R2."
1	Contextualization	[3]	3+ sentences of broader context before/during/after the topic period.
1	Evidence: 3 docs supporting thesis	[3]	Use content of 3 docs. Just cite + paraphrase.
1	Outside evidence	[4]	ONE specific historical example NOT in docs. Year/name required.
1	Evidence: 6 of 7 docs	[4]	Cite 6 docs to support thesis.
1	Sourcing (HIPP) for 3 docs	[5]	Explain Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, OR Point of view AND tie to argument.
1	Complexity	[5]	Counterargument + rebuttal, comparison across regions, OR connect to other periods.

LEQ — 6 points, 40 min [3]/[4]/[5]

Pts	Element	Tier	How to bag it
1	Thesis	[3]	Same as DBQ. Pick 1 of 3 prompts you know best.
1	Contextualization	[3]	3+ sentences of broader context.
1	Evidence: 1 specific example	[3]	Year + place + name.
1	Evidence: 2 examples support thesis	[4]	Two specific examples.
1	Reasoning (causation/comparison/CCOT)	[5]	Show HOW causes operate, or WHY similar/different, or HOW change happened.
1	Complexity	[5]	Counterargument, multi-region comparison, cross-period connection.

UNIVERSAL FRQ DISCIPLINE [3]/[4]

- **[3] Define key terms in context.** "Imperialism (the late-19th-century European political/economic domination of Africa and Asia)"
- **[3] Use specific examples** — year + place + event/person.
- **[4] Reference the theme by name** when relevant: "This reflects the GOV theme in that..."
- **[5] Make explicit comparisons across regions** when prompt allows — even when not required, this earns sophistication.

PAGE 9 | UNIVERSAL EVIDENCE BANK · events that work for many prompts

Memorize these 12 events cold. Each is flexible enough to support many DBQ/LEQ prompts about politics, economy, society, or culture.

Event (era)	Use it for prompts about...
Mongol Empire (1206-1368)	Pax Mongolica + trade, cultural exchange, technology diffusion, state-building, military innovation
Black Death (1347-53)	Disease + globalization, end of feudalism, religious change, demographic shifts
Columbian Exchange (1492+)	Biological + cultural exchange, environmental change, colonial economies, demographic catastrophe
Atlantic Slave Trade (1500-1880)	Forced migration, racialized labor, global capitalism, African diaspora, resistance
Mughal Empire (1526-1857)	Religious tolerance/intolerance, gunpowder empires, syncretism, eventual British conquest
Atlantic Revolutions (1775-1830)	Enlightenment ideas, popular sovereignty, abolition (Haiti), nation-building
Industrial Revolution (~1750-1900)	Tech + labor + environment + urbanization + capitalism + new ideologies
Scramble for Africa (1880s-1914)	Imperialism, racism, technology + power, resistance, colonial legacies
Russian Revolution (1917)	Communism, modernization, alternatives to capitalism, peasant + worker mobilization
WWII + Holocaust (1939-45)	Total war, genocide, decolonization catalyst, US-USSR ascendance, UN founding
Decolonization (1945-1975)	Self-determination, Cold War context, varied paths, lasting tensions
Globalization (1990s+)	Economic integration, cultural diffusion, environmental degradation, inequality, migration

For every prompt, ask: "Which 2 of these 12 events can I use as evidence?" That's your LEQ body. Pull just 1 for your DBQ outside-evidence point.

PAGE 10 | THE 3/4/5 SCORE LADDER · tier-specific test-day

THE SCORE LADDER — same prompt, three tiers

3-scorer writes...	4-scorer writes...	5-scorer writes...
"The British colonized India."	"The British East India Company controlled India until 1857, when the Crown took over after the Sepoy Rebellion."	"British rule shifted from Company to Crown after the Sepoy Rebellion of 1857. Comparing this to French Algeria reveals key differences: India's transition was relatively negotiated and produced a robust nationalist movement (Gandhi), while Algeria required a bloody war for independence (1954-1962). Both reflect the GOV theme of how imperial powers managed their colonies and how decolonization unfolded."
"WWI was bad."	"WWI killed 16 million and led to the Treaty of Versailles, which set up WWII."	"WWI's significance lay not just in casualties but in its character as total war that mobilized entire societies — a development that changed warfare forever. The Treaty of Versailles (1919) imposed punitive terms on Germany that, combined with the Great Depression, enabled fascism's rise. In the broader theme of GOV , WWI marked the collapse of multiple empires (Ottoman, Austro-Hungarian, Russian) and the beginning of European decline as global hegemon."
Cites 3 documents	Cites 6 documents + provides outside evidence	Sources documents (HIPP) + makes explicit cross-regional comparisons + acknowledges counterargument
States thesis once	Restates thesis in conclusion	Earns complexity point with counter-rebuttal or cross-period connection
Uses vague "Europeans" or "Asians"	Names specific regions/empires + dates	Names specific people, years, places, AND distinguishes between regions within larger categories

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — bag ALL of these:

- ✓ MCQ: 28+ correct. Eliminate by era + region.
- ✓ SAQ: each answer includes a SPECIFIC year/place/event.
- ✓ DBQ: thesis + 3-sentence context + 3 docs cited + 1 outside fact.
- ✓ LEQ: thesis + 3-sentence context + 1-2 specific examples.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 35+ correct. Drill specific dates + regional details.
- ✓ DBQ: 6 docs cited (not just 3) + 1 outside fact.
- ✓ LEQ: 2 specific examples + reasoning (causation/comparison/CCOT).
- ✓ Use specific dates + regional terms ("Tang China," "Mughal India," not just "Asia").

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 42+ correct.
- ✓ DBQ: HIPP for 3 docs + complexity move (counter+rebuttal OR comparison).
- ✓ LEQ: complexity move (counter, cross-region, cross-period).
- ✓ **Make explicit comparisons across regions** even when prompt only asks about one.
- ✓ Name themes (GOV/ECN/CDI/SOC/TEC/ENV) explicitly.
- ✓ Acknowledge alternative interpretations or competing causes.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: SPECIFICITY + COMPARISON. AP World rewards specific historical detail (year + place + name) and explicit comparison across regions/eras. Generic answers earn no points; "the British colonized India" earns 0; "the British Crown took over India in 1858 after the Sepoy Rebellion, ending East India Company rule" earns the point.

If you do nothing else: study to your tier, name specific events with years/places, and make cross-regional comparisons. That's how you hit your target.

DISCLOSURE & TERMS OF USE

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